

Module 6 — Spring Framework (IoC, DI, Beans)

Highest priority. This is the core of every Spring interview. If you can explain IoC, DI, and the bean lifecycle crisply, you clear most Spring rounds.

Node.js bridge: In Express you `require()` and `new` your dependencies yourself. Spring *inverts* that: a **container** creates and wires your objects for you (like a built-in, type-safe DI framework — think NestJS, which was inspired by Spring/Angular).

6.1 Spring Architecture & IoC (Inversion of Control)

1. Why Interviewers Ask This

IoC/DI is the whole point of Spring. “What is IoC?” and “What is the difference between IoC and DI?” are near-guaranteed openers.

2. Core Concept

- **IoC (Inversion of Control)** — you don’t create/wire dependencies; the **container** does. Control of object lifecycle is inverted from your code to the framework.
- **DI (Dependency Injection)** — the *technique* IoC uses: dependencies are **injected** (constructor/setter/field) rather than looked up or `new`d.
- **IoC Container** — `ApplicationContext` (`BeanFactory` is the lower-level base) creates, configures, wires, and manages **beans**.

IoC is the principle; DI is the implementation of that principle. This exact distinction is a frequent follow-up.

3. Internal Working — how the container boots

1. Read metadata: `@ComponentScan` finds `@Component/@Service/...` ; `@Configuration @Bean` methods
2. Build `BeanDefinitions` (class, scope, dependencies, init/destroy) in a registry
3. Instantiate singletons (eagerly by default)
4. Populate dependencies (resolve `@Autowired`) -> dependency graph
5. Run `BeanPostProcessors` (this is where AOP proxies, `@Transactional`, `@Async` wrap beans)
6. Call init callbacks (`@PostConstruct` / `InitializingBean` / `init-method`)
7. Container ready; beans served on demand

`BeanDefinitions` are metadata; the container uses them to build the object graph, detecting cycles and ordering creation.

4. Memory Diagram

```

ApplicationContext (IoC container)
+-----+
| BeanDefinition registry: |
|   OrderService -> needs PaymentGateway |
|   StripeGateway -> (no deps) |
+-----+
| instantiate + wire |
[StripeGateway singleton] <--injected-- [OrderService singleton]
  
```

5. Real Production Example

Your `OrderService` needs a `PaymentGateway`. You never write `new StripeGateway()`. You declare the dependency; Spring injects the right implementation, and in tests injects a mock — that’s the productivity and testability win of IoC.

6. Most Asked Questions

- What is IoC? Difference between IoC and DI? (*principle vs technique*)
- What is the IoC container / `ApplicationContext` vs `BeanFactory`? (*ApplicationContext = superset: events, i18n, AOP, eager singletons*)
- How does Spring know what to inject? (*by type, then by name/qualifier*)
- Benefits of DI? (*loose coupling, testability, single responsibility*)

7. Traps

- Saying IoC and DI are the same thing.
- Not knowing `ApplicationContext` extends `BeanFactory`.
- Thinking Spring uses reflection “magic” with no metadata (it builds `BeanDefinitions`).

8. Best Answer

“IoC means the framework, not my code, controls object creation and wiring. DI is how it does that — injecting collaborators instead of me `new`-ing them. The `ApplicationContext` reads bean metadata, builds a dependency graph, instantiates singletons, injects dependencies, wraps them with proxies via `BeanPostProcessors` for cross-cutting concerns, and runs init callbacks. The payoff is loose coupling and trivially mockable tests.”

9. Coding Example

```
@Service
class OrderService {
    private final PaymentGateway gateway;           // depends on abstraction
    OrderService(PaymentGateway gateway) {          // constructor injection (preferred)
        this.gateway = gateway;
    }
}

@Component
class StripeGateway implements PaymentGateway { /* ... */ }
// Spring wires StripeGateway into OrderService automatically.
```

10. Follow-ups

- What if two beans implement `PaymentGateway`? (`@Primary` or `@Qualifier`)
- How do you inject a mock in a unit test? (*constructor injection → pass the mock directly, no Spring needed*)

11 & 12. Summary + Cheat

IoC = container controls; DI = injection technique. `ApplicationContext` $\supset$ `BeanFactory`.

6.2 Dependency Injection — Constructor vs Field vs Setter

Types

- **Constructor injection (preferred)** — dependencies final, immutable, mandatory; enables testing without Spring; fails fast if missing; detects circular deps at startup.
- **Setter injection** — optional/changeable dependencies.
- **Field injection (`@Autowired` on a field)** — concise but **discouraged**: can't make fields final, hides dependencies, hard to unit test without reflection, allows circular deps to slip through.

Best Answer

“I use constructor injection: it makes dependencies explicit and final, guarantees a fully initialized object, works in plain unit tests without the Spring context, and surfaces circular dependencies at startup. Field injection is convenient but untestable and hides the contract, so I avoid it.”

```
// PREFERRED - constructor injection (no @Autowired needed if single constructor)
@Service
class UserService {
    private final UserRepository repo;
    private final EmailClient email;
    UserService(UserRepository repo, EmailClient email) { this.repo = repo; this.email = email; }
}
```

Circular dependency

$A \rightarrow B \rightarrow A$ via constructor injection **fails at startup** (`BeanCurrentlyInCreationException`). Fixes: redesign (best), `@Lazy` on one, or setter injection. Interviewers love this.

6.3 Beans, Scopes, Lifecycle

What is a Bean?

Any object instantiated, assembled, and managed by the Spring IoC container. Defined via stereotype annotations (`@Component` and friends) or `@Bean` methods in `@Configuration`.

Bean Scopes

Scope	Meaning
singleton (default)	one shared instance per container
prototype	new instance every injection/ <code>getBean</code>
request	one per HTTP request (web)
session	one per HTTP session (web)
application	one per ServletContext

Trap: singleton beans are **shared** — keep them **stateless**. A prototype injected into a singleton is created **once** (at wiring) unless you use `ObjectProvider/@Lookup`/scoped proxy.

Bean Lifecycle (guaranteed question)

```
Instantiate -> Populate properties (DI) -> *Aware callbacks (BeanNameAware...) ->
BeanPostProcessor.postProcessBeforeInitialization ->
@PostConstruct -> InitializingBean.afterPropertiesSet() -> custom init-method ->
BeanPostProcessor.postProcessAfterInitialization (AOP proxy created here) ->
[BEAN READY / IN USE] ->
@PreDestroy -> DisposableBean.destroy() -> custom destroy-method
```

- `@PostConstruct` — run init logic after DI (cache warmup, validation).
- `@PreDestroy` — cleanup (only reliably called for singletons, not prototypes).
- `BeanPostProcessor` is where Spring wraps beans in **AOP proxies** — this is how `@Transactional`, `@Async`, `@Cacheable`, and security work.

Memory Diagram

```
new Bean() -> inject deps -> @PostConstruct -> [proxy? wrap via BPP] -> READY
                                                    |
                                                    (@Transactional method call goes through proxy)
```

6.4 Stereotype & Wiring Annotations

Annotation	Meaning
<code>@Component</code>	generic Spring-managed bean
<code>@Service</code>	business logic (semantic <code>@Component</code>)
<code>@Repository</code>	data access; also translates persistence exceptions to <code>DataAccessException</code>
<code>@Controller</code>	web MVC controller (returns views)
<code>@RestController</code>	<code>@Controller</code> + <code>@ResponseBody</code> (returns JSON/body)
<code>@Configuration</code>	class of <code>@Bean</code> definitions
<code>@Bean</code>	method producing a container-managed bean (for 3rd-party classes you can't annotate)
<code>@ComponentScan</code>	discover stereotypes in packages
<code>@Autowired</code>	inject by type
<code>@Qualifier("name")</code>	disambiguate among multiple candidates
<code>@Primary</code>	default candidate when multiple exist

`@Component` VS `@Bean`

- `@Component` — class-level, auto-detected by scanning; for **your** classes.
- `@Bean` — method-level in `@Configuration`; for **third-party** classes or when you need construction logic.

`@Qualifier` VS `@Primary`

Multiple `PaymentGateway` beans → ambiguity. `@Primary` picks a default globally; `@Qualifier` picks a specific one at the injection point (overrides `@Primary`).

```
@Configuration
class AppConfig {
    @Bean @Primary PaymentGateway stripe() { return new StripeGateway(); }
    @Bean @Qualifier("paypal") PaymentGateway paypal() { return new PaypalGateway(); }
}
@Service
class Checkout {
    Checkout(@Qualifier("paypal") PaymentGateway gw) { /* gets paypal */ }
}
```

`@Configuration` internal detail (nice senior point)

`@Configuration` classes are themselves CGLIB-proxied so that inter-`@Bean` method calls return the **same singleton** rather than a new instance (unlike plain `@Bean` in a `@Component`, “Lite” mode). A frequent deep follow-up.

Module 6 — Top 25 Interview Questions (senior answers)

1. **IoC vs DI?** Principle (container controls) vs technique (inject dependencies).
2. **ApplicationContext vs BeanFactory?** Superset: eager singletons, events, i18n, AOP, auto-BPP.
3. **What is a bean?** Container-managed object built from a `BeanDefinition`.
4. **Bean scopes?** singleton (default), prototype, request, session, application.
5. **Default scope pitfall?** Singleton shared → must be stateless.
6. **Bean lifecycle?** Instantiate → DI → Aware → BPP-before → `@PostConstruct` → `afterPropertiesSet` → init → BPP-after → ready → `@PreDestroy` → destroy.
7. **@PostConstruct/@PreDestroy?** Init after DI / cleanup before destroy.
8. **What is a BeanPostProcessor?** Hook that wraps beans (AOP proxies) around init.

9. **Constructor vs field vs setter injection?** Immutable/testable vs concise-but-discouraged vs optional.
10. **Why avoid field injection?** No final, hidden deps, hard to test, hides cycles.
11. **Circular dependency handling?** Constructor cycle fails fast; fix by redesign/@Lazy/setter.
12. **@Component vs @Service vs @Repository vs @Controller?** Semantics; @Repository adds exception translation.
13. **@Controller vs @RestController?** Views vs JSON body.
14. **@Component vs @Bean?** Auto-scanned class vs method for third-party/factory.
15. **@Autowired resolution order?** By type → by qualifier/name; @Primary as default.
16. **@Qualifier vs @Primary?** Point-specific vs global default; qualifier wins.
17. **@ComponentScan?** Discovers stereotypes in base packages.
18. **Is @Autowired required?** Optional on a single constructor since Spring 4.3.
19. **Prototype in singleton problem?** Injected once; use ObjectProvider/@Lookup/scoped proxy.
20. **How is @Transactional applied?** Via AOP proxy created by a BeanPostProcessor.
21. **@Configuration CGLIB proxy?** Ensures @Bean calls return the same singleton.
22. **Lazy vs eager beans?** Singletons eager by default; @Lazy defers creation.
23. **How to define a bean for a 3rd-party class?** @Bean in @Configuration.
24. **Spring vs Spring Boot?** Framework (DI/MVC) vs opinionated auto-config on top.
25. **How to unit test a service?** Constructor-inject mocks; no context needed.

Module 6 — Top Coding Questions

- Wire two implementations and select with @Qualifier/@Primary.
- Demonstrate the bean lifecycle with @PostConstruct/@PreDestroy logging.
- Reproduce a circular dependency and fix it.
- Register a third-party client (e.g., RestTemplate/WebClient) as a @Bean.

Module 6 — Common Follow-ups

- “What actually happens at context.getBean(OrderService.class)?”
- “Why must singletons be stateless?”
- “How does @Transactional work under the hood?” (proxy + BeanPostProcessor.)

Module 6 — One-Page Cheat Sheet

```
IoC = container controls creation/wiring. DI = injection technique. ApplicationContext > BeanFactory
Lifecycle: instantiate->DI->Aware->BPP.before->@PostConstruct->afterPropertiesSet->init->BPP.after-
>READY->@PreDestroy->destroy
BeanPostProcessor wraps AOP proxies (@Transactional/@Async/@Cacheable)
Scopes: singleton(default, stateless!) prototype request session application
Injection: constructor(preferred, final, testable) > setter(optional) > field(avoid)
Circular ctor dep -> fails fast -> redesign/@Lazy/setter
@Component(class,scan) vs @Bean(method,3rd-party). @Repository=exception translation
@Autowired by type; @Qualifier(point) beats @Primary(default)
@Configuration is CGLIB-proxied -> @Bean calls share singleton
```

Module 6 — Mock Interview (answer, then continue)

1. “Explain IoC vs DI to a Node developer, with a concrete example.”
2. “Walk through the full bean lifecycle and tell me exactly where @Transactional gets applied.”

3. “You have two `PaymentGateway` beans; injection fails. Two ways to fix it and which you'd choose.”
4. “Why is constructor injection better than field injection? Convince me.”
5. “A prototype-scoped bean injected into a singleton isn't behaving as expected — why, and how do you fix it?”

Continue to Module 7 when ready.